



From Childhood Pain to Empowered Living: Zanna Barrett Walks Us Through Chronic Illness and Mindset Transformation

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Zanna has lived with chronic pain since childhood and, now in her 50s, has gained profound insights into her condition. Her journey has been fraught with challenges, but it has ultimately led her to a place of understanding and empowerment.

Early Pain, Confusion, and Social Stigma

My experience with pain began at a young age. Random chest pains, aching limbs, and persistent back pain were constant companions, though I didn't realize they weren't normal. Along with these physical symptoms came an intense fear of illness and death. In school biology classes, I noticed my breathing and pulse differed significantly from other children — slow breaths but a rapid heartbeat. With time, anxiety took over as I tried to make sense of it all. **It would be 30 years before I understood that these issues were connected to a larger, systemic condition.**

When I did express my discomfort, I was often dismissed — labeled as a “drama queen” or “lazy.”

Complaints about walking or standing for long periods were met with eye rolls. Eventually, I stopped mentioning the pain and just lived with it. Despite it all, like many children, I was resilient. I continued to play and engage with others, although the pain never fully went away.

At 12, someone finally took my symptoms seriously. A family friend, who happened to be a doctor, noticed that my gait seemed off and that I was bruising easily and

fatigued. My mental health was suffering as well. I overheard doctors mentioning leukemia, a word I knew because my grandfather had died from related pneumonia. What followed was a whirlwind of appointments and blood tests. I felt like a “gift to the vampires” with the amount of blood they took.

Finally, a diagnosis: Juvenile Rheumatoid Arthritis. While it gave a name to my symptoms, it didn't change much. The only advice was to take paracetamol.

Struggles Through Adolescence and Milestones

During my adolescence, the pain became predominantly joint-related. By the age of 14, I had been taken out of physical education and was undergoing regular physiotherapy, but there was no improvement. Fatigue took over, and I developed bladder issues that added to the discomfort. Despite consulting a new doctor who tried various medications, I stopped taking them after facing terrifying side effects. I was even advised to quit horse riding due to my hip condition, with the threat of ending up in a wheelchair. I ignored that advice, knowing that if I let it take hold, it would mentally trap me in a cycle of defeat — and I'm glad I made that choice.

As I approached adulthood, the struggle intensified, but I refused to let pain define my milestones. I celebrated my 18th birthday with a friend, dancing all night despite the discomfort. I'm sure the alcohol helped numb some of the pain, but the joy of the night was worth it.

The next day, the reality of my condition hit hard — I couldn't move, and my dad had to carry me to bed — but the celebration was something I refused to give up. Shortly after, I was diagnosed with hypermobility spectrum disorder in addition to rheumatoid arthritis. My pain worsened, and the fatigue became unbearable, affecting my ability to attend school or socialize. My neck pain was so intense at times that my dad had to help me out of bed.

University, Pregnancy, and Relapse

When I reached university, the pain had spread to my face and jaw, often causing my jaw to lock in agonizing positions until I could release it. This continued for several years, but has thankfully become less frequent over time. The pain in my fingers became so debilitating that I could no longer write by hand. My father bought me an electric typewriter to help me manage, as even now I can only write for a minute or two before the pain renders my handwriting illegible.

During pregnancy, I experienced a brief remission, which gave me a rare glimpse of life without constant pain. For the first time, I realized how abnormal my pain-filled existence had been. However, this relief was short-lived.

Once my hormones shifted after giving birth, I experienced a massive relapse. I moved back in with my parents, where my dad had to once again help me out of bed. Despite the challenges, I adapted to life as a single parent, drawing on the resilience I had built over the years. Though I managed most things on my own, there were times when I needed help with the physical demands of parenting.

Systemic Symptoms, Further Diagnoses, and Mental Health Struggles

As the years passed, my symptoms worsened, extending beyond my joints to include systemic issues. I developed GERD, causing painful heartburn, reflux, and violent bouts of vomiting that kept me up many nights. Though I'm now on medication to manage it, the treatment comes with its own set of risks. Additionally, I suffer from Irritable Bowel Syndrome (IBS), which brings considerable pain and discomfort, along with a pervasive all-over body ache. I've undergone spinal surgery due to disc degeneration and nerve damage in my neck, and I also deal with nerve damage in my right arm, carpal tunnel syndrome, and bursitis in both shoulders and hips. While steroid injections have sometimes provided relief, the underlying issues persist.

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The relentless fatigue, brain fog, anxiety, and widespread pain drove me back to rheumatology, where I was considered an anomaly. Despite years of tests, no active autoimmune disease was detected to explain my symptoms. After several years of uncertainty, I was finally diagnosed with Hypermobile Ehlers-Danlos Syndrome (hEDS), which explained the systemic issues that had become more apparent over time. Unfortunately, there is no cure for hEDS, a connective tissue disorder that can affect any part of the body, including internal organs. The focus is solely on symptom management.

Just as my consultant was ready to sign me off, deciding there was nothing more they could do, one final round of blood tests revealed additional markers for autoimmune disease. This meant starting over with more tests and uncertainty.

The mental toll has been significant. Anxiety was often the hardest to manage, as I became terrified that the next unexplained pain might be life-threatening. By my 30s, I had convinced myself I wouldn't live to see 40. When I tested positive for antibodies linked to systemic sclerosis (scleroderma), I turned to the internet and convinced myself it was game over. However, something within me shifted, and I decided not to let pain, fatigue, and anxiety control my life. I turned to Buddhist meditation and carefully practiced yoga, which helped me regain a sense of calm and resilience amidst the uncertainty.

Lifestyle Changes, Mindset, and Pain Management

Over time, I realized that to regain some control over my chronic pain, anxiety, and fatigue, I needed to focus on what I could actively change. After a year of dedicated effort — reading, researching, and shifting my mindset — I managed to reduce my pain levels. I was fortunate to have a supportive consultant who encouraged alternative therapies like ginger supplements and changes in my diet to lower inflammation. I followed the autoimmune protocol diet for a year, which provided some relief. These small but significant shifts in lifestyle and mindset helped me feel more empowered in managing my condition.

As I entered my 40s, weight gain from reduced mobility became a significant psychological burden. Meeting a coach and hypnotherapist changed everything. She helped me rebuild the confidence and self-esteem I had lost and introduced techniques that transformed my approach to symptom management. Inspired by

her methods, I invested in training, knowing that these practices could further help me manage my pain. Though I haven't "cured" my pain — it remains chronic — I've learned to manage it through meditation, hypnotherapy, and lifestyle adjustments. Using self-hypnosis, I can now dial down the pain, as well as the fatigue and anxiety. Bad days still happen, but they are less frequent and don't last as long.

Reflecting on my journey, I can see that managing pain has made me both emotionally weaker and stronger at different points in my life. I don't buy into the idea that "what doesn't kill you makes you stronger"; it just means you've dealt with it. I've learned to pace myself, ensuring I don't overdo things on good days and end up paying for it later. I also listen to my body, avoiding activities I know will trigger pain. Yes, that means missing out on some experiences, but everyone misses out on something in life.

A positive mindset has been crucial for me. When I was anxious, I would hyper-focus on my pain, making it worse. Now, by managing my anxiety, the pain has become more bearable.

Pain is very much tied to the brain, though not in the way people assume.

It doesn't mean the pain isn't real — it absolutely is — but with the right mindset and guidance, shifting focus away from it can make a world of difference in managing it.



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Constantly being in acute pain can be daunting and often a lonely journey. It is a space to rise and fall in stories of pain, healing, and co-existence.

